builder nexus, which thrived. With almost 100 additional elected corporators and their lackeys, it meant more hands in the till. "It was meant to be a single window for the city's development," says an expert. "But it turned out to be just another window to pay more speed money." With no proper zoning laws for the newly added wards, agricultural land was converted into revenue properties, resulting in an explosion of highrises, both in commercial and residential spaces in low-lying areas on the outskirts of the city. But even as posh colonies mushroomed in new areas, the infrastructure lagged, as roads remained narrow, the drainage poor, and garbage disposal too. So, while Bengaluru's IT hubs boasted glittering buildings and plush campuses, open drains, narrow streets causing traffic jams, and uncleared garbage remained an eyesore. V. Ravichandar, honorary director of the Bangalore International Centre and a city evangelist who has been waging a losing battle to save it, terms it "private splendour amid public squalor".

3. Greed versus Green

The recent floods, says Ravichandar, were a disaster waiting to happen since successive city administrators have messed with the natural flow of rainwater while sanctioning its expansion. Bengaluru's topography holds the clue to why water management is key. The old city came up on a central ridge line that runs north to south. Rainwater falling east of this ridge drains into valleys, filling up the numerous interlinked man-made lakes downstream. This is where the city's storm water drain (SWD) network came in—these primary canals, known locally as *rajakaluve*s, were once natural rain-fed streams across which farmers built small bunds over time to arrest the flow of water and create lakes. When one lake filled up, water was let out downstream via sluice gates to the next lake.

The city administrators made their third big mistake when, to meet the demand for space for construction and roads, they allowed lakes to be breached regularly. The lakes, which once numbered a thousand-odd, are now reduced to a paltry 200 or so. Worse, the *rajakaluve*s that channelised the storm water had buildings built over them. Bellandur, the tiny village from which Bengaluru's best-known lake takes its name, is today a mass of buildings and shanties sitting cheek-by-jowl alongside business parks—a thriving ecosystem that provides everything from paying guest accommodation to shops and restaurants. Leo F. Saldanha, the coordinator of the non-profit Environment Support Group, which has been litigating for lake preservation for over two decades, says, "All these were natural agricultural wetlands. But while putting up buildings, planners should have ensured space for water to collect and interlinkages to lakes downstream if they overflowed. It was a very simple thing to do, but we ignored it and the citizens are paying the



SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

CITIZENSPEAK

'Deep corruption should be rooted out'

T.V. MOHANDAS PAI, *62*
Chairman, Manipal Global Education

You can't find a more quintessential Bangalorean than T.V. Mohandas Pai. The former Infosys CFO and angel investor went to school and college in the city. He is now the chairperson of Manipal Global Education and is also the co-founder of Akshaya Patra, which runs the world's largest mid-day meal programme. Pai is enraged that the Bengaluru he grew up in has gone to seed.

"The city's municipal corporation has become too big, it has one commissioner who administers 800 sq. km with 12 million people." Pai suggests implementing a pending law to break up the municipality into five corporations. However, he knows that the current government won't do it because "city MLAs don't want to give up their power". He speaks about the "deep corruption" in most civic bodies, "where posts are sold, people openly make money for projects, nobody is sacked and everybody who benefits lives happily while the city suffers". He is dismissive of plans to decongest Bengaluru by building a twin city: "It will be another real estate venture and won't solve the problem."